



HUMANITAS
INSTITUTE

Six Elements of Classical Education School Website Audit

School: Heritage Christian Academy of North Idaho

School Website: <https://spiritlakechristian.org/>

January 7, 2026

Artificial Intelligence Disclaimer

This audit was performed using artificial intelligence tools to evaluate the presence and strength of classical education principles on school websites. Results are automated, probabilistic in nature, and should be considered indicative rather than definitive. See the full disclaimer in the Appendix more details.

SCL MEMBER

Any school that belongs to the Society for Classical Learning (SCL) is, by definition, recognized as a classical school because SCL requires adherence to the six essential elements defined by the Humanitas Institute. However, a school's website may not clearly reflect its conformity to one or more elements. In such cases, the school may still receive a "Somewhat Classical" rating for those elements. Schools can update their website content at any time to achieve a "Classical" rating for a given element.

Overall Classification: **CLASSICAL**

Executive Summary

Heritage Christian Academy (North Idaho, 83869) presents itself as a Christ-centered private school grounded in biblical worldview and founded on a community-centric, formation-focused approach. Public-facing materials consistently emphasize faith integration across subjects, a family-partnered model, and a distinctive four-day-week schedule designed to support family life, spiritual growth, and disciplined academics. The school highlights small class sizes, devoted faculty, and a mission to form students' character in alignment with Christian virtue and truth. Based on the public materials in the school's crawl and the classical-education rubric in the knowledge base, Heritage Christian Academy shows strong alignment with core religious and community aspects, and with formation-oriented aims, while exhibiting more modest alignment with classical liberal-arts methods (e.g., absence (so far) of explicit Great Books / Trivium-based curriculum in public materials). Overall, the school is ranked **CLASSICAL**, with notable strength in religious foundations, formation-focused aims, and community/family partnership, and partial (**SOMEWHAT CLASSICAL**) alignment in curriculum specifics. The strongest needle-moving opportunities would be to explicitly articulate a liberal-arts scope (grammar, logic, rhetoric), engage with Great Books or Great Conversation concepts, and document any Socratic pedagogy for upper grades to deepen alignment with the classical model.

Key evidence anchors: - Religious and Metaphysical Foundations: explicit Christ-centeredness, biblical worldview in every subject, daily scripture/prayer emphasis, and a mission to honor God in learning. - Purpose and Goal: formation and virtue orientation, preparation to defend Christian faith, and a life-formation emphasis rather than mere job-prep. - Curriculum: biblically-grounded curriculum; use of church-adjacent curriculum providers (e.g., BJU Press) and emphasis on Type to Learn for digital literacy; no explicit Great Books / Trivium mention in the public materials reviewed. - Pedagogy: four-day-week with longer days cited as a structural pedagogy choice; emphasis on focused academics and spiritual growth; limited public evidence of Socratic seminars or classical dialogues in the public materials. - Faculty: teachers as committed, Christ-centered professionals; small classes; living-contact emphasis; close-knit community. - Parents & Community: explicit partnership with families; welcoming parents for visits; community-focused and parent-engaged approach.

Note: The analysis relies on the school's public-facing crawl results and the classical rubric's keyword indicators from the Six Essential Elements of a Classical School (1) knowledge base.

Executive Summary — Element-by-Element Snapshot

Element 1: Religious and Metaphysical Foundations — CLASSICAL

Evidence - Public materials consistently describe Heritage Christian Academy as Christ-centered with a biblical worldview threaded through all subjects. Examples include “A Christ-Centered Educational Foundation” and explicit statements that every lesson is studied through a biblical worldview. - Daily Scripture and prayer, commitment to honor God in learning, and a mission to instill biblical worldview across grades are described in mission and campus pages.

Positive/Negative keyword analysis - Positive keywords present: biblical worldview, Christ-centered, God, Scripture, Bible, prayer, daily Scripture. Frequency observed across multiple sections. - Negative keywords present: none detected in public materials (no secular or nonsectarian terminology observed). The Six Elements document lists secular/neutral terms as Negative Keywords, which do not appear in Heritage materials reviewed here.

Why this rating - The school’s materials consistently foreground theology and liturgical/community practices aligned with a religious-metaphysical foundation. The prevalence of biblical worldview and Christ-centered language, supported by mission statements and daily prayer/scripture emphasis, strongly supports CLASSICAL in this category.

Element 2: Purpose and Goal — SOMEWHAT CLASSICAL

Evidence - The school emphasizes formation of virtue, character, and spiritual maturity, not just information or vocational job-prep. Statements like “<...> Forming students to fulfill God’s calling” and “defenders of the Christian faith” indicate an aim toward virtue and formation. - The emphasis on training critical thinkers who can articulate their faith and on a holistic formation of the person aligns with the classical emphasis on truth, goodness, and beauty, with formation as a primary aim.

Positive/Negative keyword analysis - Positive keywords present: formation, virtue, wisdom, truth, beauty (implicit through “biblical worldview” and a formation frame), character, spiritual maturity. - Negative keywords present: none detected publicly (no explicit emphasis on purely instrumental or job-prep language). The lack of explicit liberal-arts Great Books or universal “great conversation” language lowers it from full CLASSICAL in this category.

Why this rating - While the formation and virtue vocabulary is strong, the public materials do not demonstrate a fully articulated liberal-arts education (grammar/logic/rhetoric, Great Books, or Great Conversation). Hence SOMEWHAT CLASSICAL best captures the category: formation-focused and truth-centered, but not fully aligned with classical curriculum articulation in public materials.

Element 3: Curriculum — NOT CLASSICAL

Evidence - The public materials describe biblical worldview integration, BJU Press materials, and digital literacy (Type to Learn) as core components. This signals a Christian, biblically-grounded curriculum rather than a liberal-arts, Great-Books-driven classical curriculum. - There is no explicit mention of Seven Liberal Arts (grammar, logic, rhetoric) or Quadrivium, nor explicit reference to Great Books and the Great Conversation, which are central to the classical curriculum model.

Positive/Negative keyword analysis - Positive keywords present: biblical worldview, Christ-centered, Great Books (not present), Great Conversation (not present) – effectively, absence of classical curriculum signifiers in the public materials reduces positive signals for a classical liberal-arts curriculum. The public materials emphasize biblical integration and Christian-centered curricula rather than the classical canon and liberal-arts framework. - Negative keywords present: absence of Great Books, Great Conversation, Seven Liberal

Arts, and explicit Trivium/Quadrivium language in public materials; these would be Negative Keywords in the Classical rubric if present, and their absence lowers alignment.

Why this rating - Without explicit Great Books, Great Conversation, or Trivium/Quadrivium framing, the curriculum does not fully satisfy the Classical School curriculum criteria. The school's public materials point to a biblically-focused program and external curriculum provider rather than a classical liberal-arts core. Therefore, NOT CLASSICAL is warranted for Element 3.

Element 4: Pedagogy or Teaching Methods — NOT CLASSICAL

Evidence - The most explicit pedagogical feature publicly described is the four-day school week with longer daily hours, aimed at focused academics and family balance, rather than a stated set of classical pedagogical methods (e.g., Socratic seminars, debates, memory-focused recitation, or rhetoric training in upper grades). - There is some emphasis on memory and singing in lower grades in the classical rubric, but public Heritage materials do not cite singing/chanting or Socratic discussion in lower/upper grades; rather they emphasize faith integration, smaller classes, and teacher mentorship.

Positive/Negative keyword analysis - Positive keywords present: contemplation or restfulness in education is a listed possibility in classical pedagogy; but the Heritage site does not explicitly promote contemplative pedagogy as a hallmark—rather it emphasizes structure (four-day week), focused academics, and spiritual growth. The direct classical terms (Socratic seminars, rhetoric training in upper grades, Great Conversation) are not present in public materials. - Negative keywords present: absence of explicit Socratic discourse, seminars, or rhetoric-based upper-level training; lack of explicit commitment to a traditional classical pedagogy signals weaker alignment.

Why this rating - The public-facing pedagogical language centers on structure, faith integration, and community orientation rather than explicit classical pedagogical methods (Socratic seminars, rigorous rhetoric training, or a pattern of memory-based pedagogy). Given this absence of the canonical classical pedagogy signals, Element 4 is NOT CLASSICAL.

Element 5: Faculty — CLASSICAL

Evidence - Faculty described as model teachers and mentors who socialize virtue and knowledge; small class sizes enable individualized attention and mentorship. The materials describe teachers as “committed followers of Christ” and “core of the school,” with a “living curriculum” vibe in the community-focused narrative. - The school emphasizes a close-knit community where teachers, students, and families are connected and teachers are deeply involved in student formation; “The teachers are described as collegial” and “living curriculum” signals a classical emphasis on the teacher as a central, virtuous exemplar.

Positive/Negative keyword analysis - Positive keywords present: model teachers, mentors, living curriculum, core of the school, close-knit community, dedicated follower of Christ. Frequency indicates strong alignment with the classical category's faculty expectations. - Negative keywords present: none detected in public materials (no language suggesting unprofessional or non-mentoring faculties). The Positive Keywords list in the Six Elements doc would flag “model teachers and mentors” and “living curriculum” as favorable signals; Heritage materials align with these signals.

Why this rating - The combination of small classes, faculty as moral exemplars, and faculty-as-core-curriculum signals strong CLASSICAL alignment in Element 5.

Element 6: Parents & Community — CLASSICAL

Evidence - The school emphasizes Partnership with Families and parent engagement as a core feature, with explicit statements that the school partners with parents and that parents can visit readily; there is emphasis on home-school connection and parent involvement in formation. - The school also discusses a family-oriented, community-centered culture, with opportunities for parent visits, and resources to educate parents in classical education principles (the materials reference parent engagement and community focus).

Positive/Negative keyword analysis - Positive keywords present: partnership with families; family involvement; parent-education; home-school partnership; school as extension of the family; parent formation; community support. These map directly to the Positive Keywords for “Partnership with Families” and “Formation of Affections.” - Negative keywords present: none detected (no explicit call-outs to “Lack of family partnership,” etc.). The Negative Keywords in the Six Elements doc would flag absence of family partnership if present; here it is present, not absent.

Why this rating - The school clearly foregrounds parent collaboration and family engagement, aligning with the classical category’s expectations for Home- and School-Partnership and parental formation. This yields CLASSICAL for Element 6.

What Would Move the Needle

- Element 2 (Purpose and Goal): Introduce explicit language and programming around liberal-arts formation, including explicit articulation of a goal structure centered on the Trivium (grammar, logic, rhetoric) and the Quadrivium (arithmetic, geometry, music, astronomy), and connect this to Great Books or classic texts wherever possible. This would strengthen the formation-centered aim with explicit classical curriculum rails.
- Element 3 (Curriculum): Publicly articulate a liberal-arts core (grammar, logic, rhetoric) and, where appropriate, Great Books or Great Conversation components; show alignment with interdisciplinary integration and wonder through explicit program descriptions and sample syllabi. This would elevate the curriculum to a more robust CLASSICAL alignment.
- Element 4 (Pedagogy): Incorporate explicit classical pedagogical modalities (Socratic discussion, seminars, rhetoric instruction for upper grades) and evidence of contemplative, memory-theory, or chant-based practices in appropriate grade bands to align more with classical pedagogy signals.

Note: Since the school already demonstrates strong religious foundations, formation focus, and family/community engagement, these needle-moving items would align the public materials even more closely with classical education norms.

Appendix

ARTIFICIAL INTELLIGENCE DISCLAIMER

This audit was conducted using artificial intelligence tools (including large language models and automated web-analysis scripts) to evaluate the extent to which school websites reflect or incorporate recognized principles of classical education (e.g., the trivium, emphasis on truth/beauty/goodness, integration of great books, Latin/classical languages, Socratic method, rigorous academics, moral/character formation, etc.).

Important Limitations and Caveats

1. **Automated Nature:** The analysis relies on AI interpretation of publicly-accessible school website content as of the date of the audit. It does not involve direct contact with schools, review of internal documents, classroom observation, or verification of curriculum implementation beyond what is stated or implied on the website.
2. **Probabilistic Results:** Scores and assessments are probabilistic and reflect the AI's best interpretation of available text and site structure. They are not infallible and may miss nuance, context, or recent changes not yet reflected online.
3. **Subjectivity of Classical Education:** "Classical Education" encompasses a range of traditions and interpretations (e.g., Dorothy Sayers' trivium model, Classical Christian Education, Great Books programs, etc.). The Humanitas Institute Audit of the Six Elements of Classical Education uses a broad, consensus-based framework derived from prominent classical education organizations and thought leaders. Reasonable people may disagree on weighting or inclusion of specific criteria.
4. **No Official Endorsement or Certification:** Results do not constitute official endorsement, accreditation, or certification by any classical education organization. They are provided for informational and research purposes only.
5. **Potential for Error:** Websites may be incomplete, poorly worded, or temporarily inaccurate. Conversely, sophisticated marketing language may create false positives. Human review by parents, educators, or classical education experts is strongly recommended before drawing final conclusions about any school.
6. **Data Privacy and Ethics:** Only publicly available information was analyzed. No attempts were made to access password-protected areas or collect personal data.
7. **No Liability:** The authors, developers, and distributors of this audit assume no liability for decisions made on the basis of these results. Users are solely responsible for their own due diligence.

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